

How Your Commute Ended Up Kicking the Dog

Draft, awaiting author approval. Not posted.

Subject lines

1. You snapped at the door. The dog paid for it.
2. When the whole house is off, check who came home last
3. How five words about the dishwasher ruined dinner

A bad day at work can make it all the way through your house and finish on the dog before dinner's on the table. You don't even have to yell. One snap at the front door does it. Nothing dramatic, just edges, and the rest of the house takes it from there without you. Most of us know what it's like to walk into somebody else's bad mood. This time the mood that wrecked the evening came in with you, and by the time it reached the dog you were upstairs changing your shirt.

You've just spent forty minutes behind a truck that brakes for every shadow, right after a meeting that should have been an email. You come through the door with your jaw still set. She asks if you called about the dishwasher. You say "I said I'd do it" in a voice that means you didn't, and also that the subject is closed. That's the whole offense, and you know it. She goes back to the kitchen, where the kids are supposedly doing homework. The next thing she says is "Feet. Off the table. Now," in a tone she didn't have at four o'clock. Your oldest gets told twice about his math, so he tells his little sister to get out of his room. His sister, now out of people smaller than her, shoves the dog off the couch with her foot. The dog did nothing. He spent the afternoon asleep in a patch of sun and has no opinion about the dishwasher.

Nobody in that house decided to hand it on. She wasn't punishing the kids, and they

weren't punishing the dog. It just went from one person to the next until there was nobody left. That's how your seven-year-old ends up in timeout over a meeting she wasn't in.

Marcus Aurelius was a Roman emperor who kept a private journal through years of war and plague. He wrote a lot about the part of a man that decides what a moment means. His *Meditations*, in the Haines translation, puts it this way at 6.8: "The ruling Reason it is that can arouse and deflect itself, make itself whatever it will, and invest everything that befalls with such a semblance as it wills."

He's saying the part of you in charge can wind itself up or settle itself down. It also decides what a lousy commute means once you're home. The truck and the meeting weren't your call. What they turned into at your front door was.

Her mood is hers, and the kids' moods are theirs. Some nights the evening really does

start with her long day, or with a kid who got left out at recess. What you bring through the door is yours. When the whole house is off around seven-thirty, the first question most of us reach for is who's being difficult. A better one is when it started and who was standing there. Going back one person at a time takes you about ten seconds. The dog got it from the youngest, the youngest got it from her brother, and he got it in the kitchen. Sometimes it ends at her day or at the school, and then you know something about her afternoon you didn't know at six. A lot of nights, if you're honest, it ends in the front hall at 6:15, with a guy still holding his car keys.

The dog, meanwhile, is back on his bed by the front door, waiting to see who walks in next.

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You don't have to yell to wreck a whole evening. One snap at the front door, nothing dramatic, just edges, and it gets all the way through the house to the dog by dinner. Nobody decided to hand it on. The dog did nothing.

[Substack link]

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She asks if you called about the dishwasher. You say "I said I'd do it" in a voice that closes the subject. Forty minutes later your youngest is shoving the dog off the couch and getting sent to her room for it.

[Substack link]

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When the whole house is off by seven-thirty, most of us start by asking who's being difficult. The better question is when it started and who was standing in the front hall. Some nights it's her long day or a rough one at school. A lot of nights it's a guy still holding his car keys.

[Substack link]

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A bad day at work can make it all the way through your house and finish on the dog before dinner's on the table. You don't have to yell for that. One short answer at the front door does it, and everybody after you hands it along without meaning to. The dog, for the record, did nothing. Full piece: [Substack link]

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A Calm House Doesn't Prove You're a Calm Guy

Draft, awaiting author approval. Not posted.

Subject lines

1. A quiet month with her doesn't make you a patient man
2. The small tell in how you answer her on no sleep
3. Who are you to her when nobody has slept in four days?

Staying calm in a quiet house doesn't prove you're a calm guy. It might just mean it's been a quiet month. Nobody's sick and the kids are asleep by eight. By the third easy week you've started telling yourself you've finally got this patience thing down. Plenty of us have had that month. A few of us have said so out loud, which is roughly when the universe starts taking notes. **You can't be a boxer without being punched in the face.** A quiet month

hasn't asked your patience to do anything yet, except take the credit.

Then the week shows up. The youngest gets the stomach bug at 2 a.m., and by breakfast the middle one has it too. Somebody puts a towel down in the hallway, and it stays there all week as policy. The car starts making the noise, the one that sounds expensive. Your mom calls Wednesday, very cheerful, to say the doctor just wants a few more tests.

Nobody in the house has slept more than four hours, and that includes both of you. The dishwasher has been full of clean dishes since Monday because neither of you has had ninety seconds to empty it. None of it came from her, and none of it came from you. It landed on both of you at once, and it's the first week all month that has told you anything.

Seneca was a Roman statesman, and he wrote letters to his friend Lucilius about how to live. He told Lucilius that "no prizefighter can go

with high spirits into the strife if he has never been beaten black and blue” (Seneca, *Letters* 13, Gummere translation). He means you don’t get to trust yourself under pressure until you’ve been under some. The guy who gets to walk in confident, by Seneca’s account, is the one who’s had his teeth rattled and got up every time. A month of the kids asleep by eight was never going to teach you that. It was a great month. It just wasn’t a test.

The next time something real lands, the tell is usually small. For a lot of men it’s a sentence that starts with “Can everybody just.” Or she asks whether anyone called the pharmacy, and you answer like she asked it to annoy you. She’s running on the same four hours you are. None of that makes you a bad husband. It means you’re finding out now what the quiet month couldn’t tell you. The other kind of calm is plainer than you’d expect. You’re wrecked, you’re worried about your mom, and

her question about the pharmacy still sounds like a question about the pharmacy. She's finding out the same thing about herself, by the way, in front of the same full dishwasher.

On Saturday the guy at the shop says the noise is a loose bracket on the exhaust, and it costs forty bucks.

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Option 1 (counterintuitive)

You can't be a boxer without being punched in the face. A quiet month at home, nobody sick and the kids asleep by eight, hasn't tested your patience once. It's just been a nice month.

[Substack link]

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Option 2 (story-led)

The youngest gets the stomach bug at 2 a.m. By breakfast the middle one has it, the car is making the noise, and nobody in the house has slept more than four hours. That's the week that tells you what kind of calm you actually have.

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Option 3 (practical)

The tell is usually small. She asks whether anyone called the pharmacy, and you answer like she asked it to annoy you. She's on the same four hours of sleep you are, and she's finding out the same thing about herself.

[Substack link]

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Plenty of us have had an easy month at home and quietly decided we'd finally figured out patience. Then the stomach bug shows up at 2 a.m., the car starts making the noise, and nobody in the house sleeps more than four hours. That week lands on both of you, and it's the first one that tells you anything. You can't be a boxer without being punched in the face.

Full piece: [Substack link]

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You Read Some Stoicism and Went Behind Glass

Draft, awaiting author approval. Not posted.

Subject lines

1. Feeling as bad as she does won't help her
2. The first ten seconds after she tells you something hard
3. What she sees when you nod through her awful week

If you've read a little Stoicism, there's a decent chance you've tried the version where you turn into a very calm houseplant. She tells you about her awful week and you nod slowly, like she's walking you through a quarterly report you didn't ask to see. You're calm, sure. You're also no help to her at all, and she can tell. Somewhere between the reading and the couch, a lot of us decided steady meant watching her from behind glass.

The opposite mistake looks a lot more loving. She's fried, so you get fried with her. You sigh

in all the right places and get angrier at her boss than she is. By nine o'clock you're both at the kitchen table feeling terrible. That feels like being on her side. In practice, two people in a low is a lower low. She brought you one bad week. Now she has her week plus your reaction to it, and your reaction is one more thing she has to manage. It works the same in the other direction. When you're the one having the awful week, what helps is someone in the room who stays kind and level while you're low.

The Stoics were Greek and Roman philosophers from about two thousand years ago. They put a lot of weight on the part of you that decides what a moment means and what you do about it. Keeping that part in charge was most of the work, and it was never a way to care less. Say she's sick, the miserable kind, and you walk in with soup. You're warm. You make one small, quiet joke

that lightens the room without brushing off how bad she feels. You're not swept into her misery, and you're not performing cool from across the room either. You're just steady, and that steadiness turns out to be the thing you brought her, along with the soup.

The next time she tells you something hard, a lot gets decided in the first ten seconds. In the nodding version, your eyes stay where they were and you wait for her to finish. The warm version is mostly small physical stuff. You turn around from the counter and put the phone face down. You sit close enough that your knee touches hers. Then you say one thing back that proves you caught the specific part. "Wait, the same person who approved it is now blaming you for it?" The joke waits until she's had a while to be mad out loud, and it's aimed at the situation or at you. It takes about ten seconds and no speeches.

The soup can come from a can.

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Option 1 (counterintuitive)

Getting just as upset as she is feels like loyalty. Two people in a low is a lower low. Now she's handling her bad week and your reaction to it.

[Substack link]

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Option 2 (story-led)

She tells you about her awful week. You nod slowly, like she's walking you through a quarterly report. Very calm. No help at all.

[Substack link]

#Stoicism #HusbandLife #MarriedMan

Option 3 (practical)

The next time she tells you something hard, the first ten seconds do most of the work. You turn around from the counter, the phone goes face down, and you sit close enough that your knee touches hers. The joke can wait.

[Substack link]

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A lot of us read a little Stoicism and decided being steady meant staying calm and a little far away. So she tells you about her hard week and gets a very polite nod. The better version is soup when she's sick and one small joke that makes the room lighter without brushing her off. It's steady and warm at the same time, and it starts in about ten seconds.

Full piece: [Substack link]

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